

Digilians

Leadership Skills

Module Three

LEADERSHIP SKILLS

Participant's Manual



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Interpersonal Skills of Leaders

The need for human-centric leadership has increased sharply. Interpersonal skills are vital for leaders to build trust, motivate teams, and navigate organizational change. These skills enable effective communication, conflict resolution, and higher employee engagement, ultimately increasing retention. Key competencies include empathy, emotional intelligence, problem solving, and active listening, which foster a productive, positive, and collaborative workplace culture.

Key Reasons Interpersonal Skills are Critical for Leaders:

- **Building Trust and Relationships:** Leaders with strong interpersonal skills create a safe environment, establishing trust and mutual respect, which is crucial for team cohesion.

- **Enhanced Communication:** Effective verbal and nonverbal communication ensures goals are clear and feedback is constructive, which 50.66% of surveyed leaders found to be a top skill.
- **Motivating Employees:** Leaders who demonstrate empathy and genuinely care about their team members increase engagement and create a more motivated, resilient, and productive workforce.
- **Effective Conflict Management:** The ability to address disagreements with objectivity and empathy allows leaders to turn conflicts into positive outcomes, improving team dynamics.
- **Navigating Change and Uncertainty:** In times of high stress and rapid organizational change, leaders with high emotional intelligence (EQ) provide stability and confidence to their team.
- **Fostering Collaboration:** By bridging connections between diverse team members, leaders facilitate better teamwork and a more inclusive environment.

Key Skills of Leaders



Executive Presence

It is a dynamic blend of **confidence**, **composure**, **credibility** and **authenticity** that allows leaders to command respect, inspire trust, and influence others, particularly in high-stakes situations.

What is Self-confidence?

- Self-confidence is simply believing in oneself.
- It is an individual's trust in his or her own abilities, capacities, and judgments, or belief that he or she can successfully face day to day challenges and demands.

High Versus Low Self Confidence Behaviors

High Self- Confidence	Low Self-Confidence
Doing what you believe to be right, even if others mock or criticize you for it.	Governing your behavior based on what other people think.
Being willing to take risks and go the extra mile to achieve better things.	Staying in your comfort zone, fearing failure, and so avoid taking risks.
Admitting your mistakes and learning from them.	Talking about your talents all the time to everyone
Speaking only when the topic is within your area of expertise	Covering up for mistakes so no one knows about them
Accepting compliments. "Thanks, I really worked hard on that project. I appreciate you recognizing my efforts."	Dismissing compliments saying, "Oh that project was nothing really, anyone could have done it."

How to Build Confidence

- Strengths inventory
- Evidence list
- Recall confidence situations
- Micro challenges (uncomfortable actions; one daily)
- Positive visualization
- Teach something
- Document success

Credibility & Accountability

Credibility is the quality of being trusted and believed, while accountability is the obligation to take responsibility for actions and results. Together, they form the foundation of professional trust, ethical leadership, and organizational effectiveness, where consistent accountability builds, and reinforces, long-term credibility.

Key Connections Between Credibility and Accountability:

- **Trust and Reliability:** Accountability means owning outcomes—both successes and failures—which builds reliability and, in turn, boosts credibility.
- **Consistency is Key:** Accountability loses credibility when consequences are inconsistent, delayed, or perceived as selective, particularly in leadership.
- **Transparency:** Openly sharing progress and admitting mistakes (transparency) proves accountability, which strengthens an individual or organization's reputation.
- **Cultural Impact:** In the workplace, encouraging accountability creates a culture of responsibility and trust, while in public sectors, it ensures ethics and public confidence.
- **The 6 A's of Accountability:** A popular framework for restoring credibility is: **A**ccept, **A**dmit, **A**pologize, **A**ct, **A**mend, and **A**ttend.

Actionable Ways to Build Accountability and Credibility:

- **Take Ownership:** Take personal responsibility for actions and results, rather than deflecting or making excuses.
- **Set Clear Expectations:** Define goals and deadlines clearly to ensure everyone knows what they are responsible for.
- **Follow Through:** Ensure actions align with promises to create predictable, trustworthy behavior.

- **Admit Mistakes:** Be honest and open about shortcomings to demonstrate professional integrity and a desire to improve.
- **Seek Feedback:** Actively ask for input to ensure accountability is being met and to improve performance.

REMEMBER

Be responsible
for results

Do what you
say

No blame

No excuses

Problem Solving

What is a Problem?

It is a gap between the current situation and the desired situation.

Vague Versus Well-defined Problems

- Client is unhappy (vague)
- My startup isn't growing (vague)
- Team is demotivated (vague)
- Sales are down (vague)
- Monthly sales dropped 25% in the last 2 months after price increase (well-defined)
- 60% of users stopped using the app within the first 7 days (well-defined)

Problem Solving Process

- **Define the Problem:** Identify the root cause rather than just the symptoms.
- **Generate Solutions:** Brainstorm multiple possible solutions without judgment.
- **Evaluate Alternatives:** Weigh the pros and cons of each solution and pick the best solution
- **Implement the Solution:** Put the chosen plan into action.
- **Evaluate/Monitor Outcomes:** Assess whether the solution solved the problem, and refine as necessary.

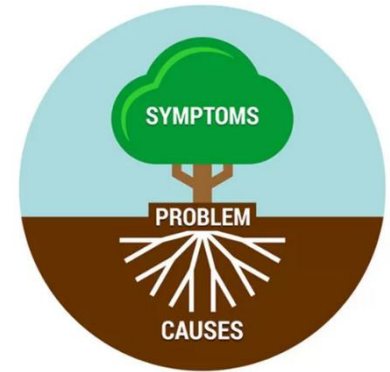


Problem

A problem is the ROOT CAUSE causing the symptom. It usually requires analysis and questioning to uncover.

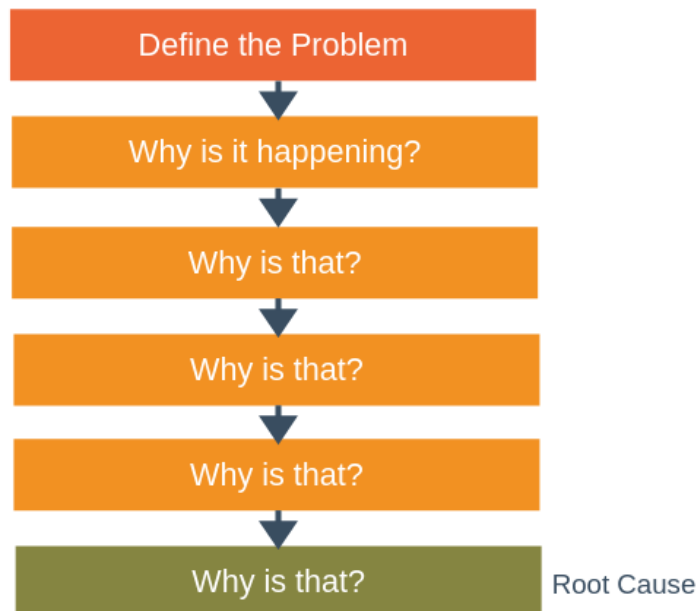
Symptom

A symptom is what you see, feel, or experience on the surface. It is the signal that something is wrong, but it is not the real issue.



Identifying Root Cause of Problems

The 5 Whys



Example

A freelance web developer keeps missing project deadlines, and clients are becoming dissatisfied.

Why is the freelancer missing project deadlines?
Because tasks are taking longer than planned.

Why are tasks taking longer than planned?
Because the freelancer frequently underestimates the time needed to complete features and fix bugs.

Why does the freelancer underestimate the time needed?
Because project requirements are not fully clarified at the beginning, and unexpected changes appear during development.

Why are the project requirements not fully clarified at the beginning?

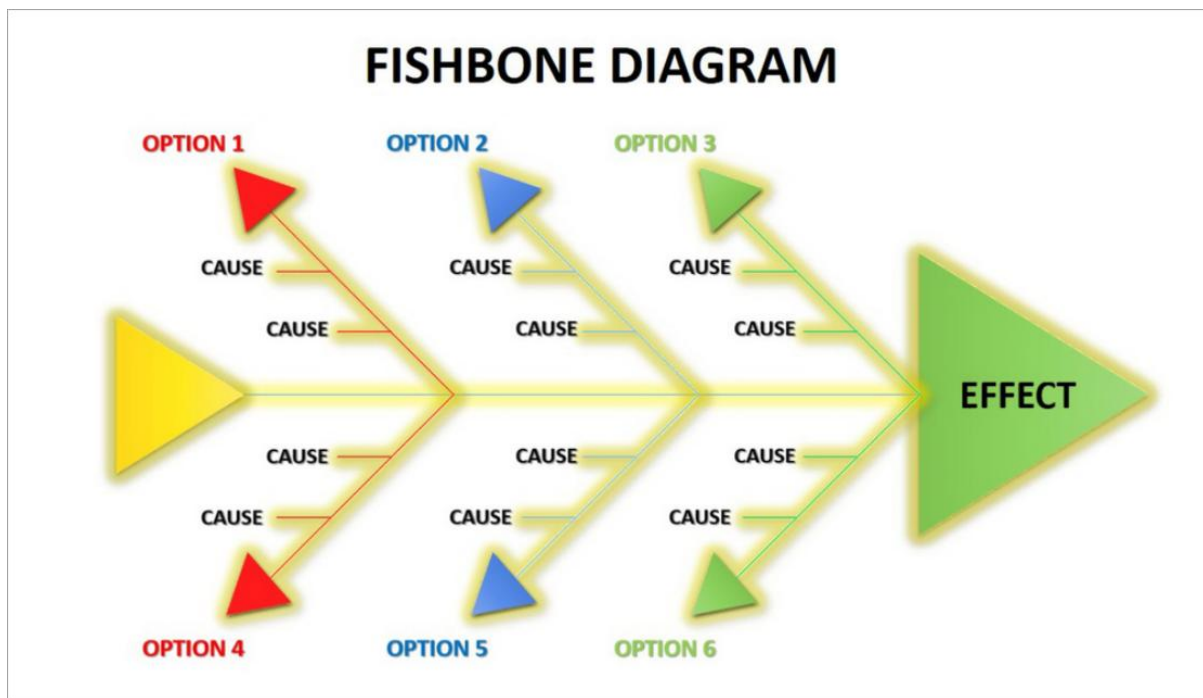
Because the freelancer rushes into starting work without asking detailed questions or documenting client expectations.

Why does the freelancer rush into starting work?

Because they are afraid of losing the client to another freelancer and want to appear fast and flexible.

- SYMPTOM: A freelance web developer keeps missing project deadlines, and clients are becoming dissatisfied
- ROOT CAUSE IDENTIFIED
The freelancer lacks a structured project scoping process and prioritizes speed over clarity due to fear of losing clients.

Fishbone Diagram



Evaluating Alternatives

Establish a clear set of standards to measure each alternative against.

Key criteria include:

- Feasibility: Can it be realistically achieved within constraints?
- Cost: What is the total cost or ROI?
- Risk: What are the potential negative consequences or failure points?
- Impact: How well does it solve the problem or align with goals?
- Time: How long will implementation take?

Decision Making

A decision is the act of choosing between two or more options to move toward a desired outcome.

Remember

There are no perfect decisions – only **CONSEQUENCES**

Example

Choose between:

- A low-paying long-term client
- A high-paying short-term project

Decision Making Criteria

1. Current financial obligations
2. Type of client (key account)
3. Number of current clients
4. Project scope
5. Project team and availability

Decision Making Frameworks

- Pros and Cons list
- The “Eisenhower Matrix”
- The “Circle of Influence”
- The 10-10-10 Rule (good for emotional decisions)

Situations

1. You have a stable well-paying job that you find boring. You receive an offer from a startup that pays less and has less job security but offers more benefits and you're passionate about the job. **Do you stay or go?**
2. You have 2 final candidates for a role. Candidate A has slightly less experience but fits the company culture perfectly and has high potential. Candidate B is a proven expert but has a history of conflict with team members. **Who do you hire?**
3. Your analytics team discovers that a subtle change in the user interface makes users spend 20% more money, but they don't realize they are spending it. Implementing this would hit your quarterly targets. **Do you launch the feature?**
4. One of your top performers (who generates 30% of your department's output) has started coming in late, dressing down, and being short with colleagues. **Do you confront them immediately and risk them quitting, or do you let it slide to maintain productivity?**

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LEADERSHIP SKILLS
